



Google's Project Glass

Dawn of a new future or a spiced-up borrowed idea?

Many have experimented with the technology Google is playing around with these days. Why bother? Read on...

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For quite some time now, tech circles have been abuzz with Google's latest venture. The company apparently hired augmented reality (AR) experts to come up with something similar to Oakley's Thump sunglasses which have built-in audio players. On April 4, when the first look of its Glass Project was finally revealed, reactions poured in from all corners. From creating euphoria at the wonderful, mind-blowing possibilities ahead to facing skepticism towards the technical feasibility and practicality of a pair of glasses you're forced to wear all day long, Google managed to do what it does best – capture the world's imagination to show us a future which seems mystical and yet achievable. Even those doubtful about it will have to accept that the lifestyle predicted runs very high on the cool factor! Check out the video <http://dgit.in/glassproj> if you haven't already.

The team behind the project seems very capable. And excited. Just a day after the unveiling of its video, Google co-founder Sergey Brin was spotted wearing a possible prototype at a fund raising dinner. How soon the product will be in your hands, though, is a question still far from being answered. The question we're exploring today is: how original is the idea itself? Let's take a closer look.

The technology

Augmented Reality is a live, direct or indirect view of a physical environment that's made possible by computer-generated input including sound, video, graphics and GPS data. Science has been trying to bring the physical and the vir-



Snapshot of the heads up display of the Google Glass Project

tual worlds closer since forever now, and AR is the fast merging boundary between the two. Its applications are unbelievably vast and impressive.

Like most revolutionary technological innovations of our times, this too grew out of university labs. Consequently, there now exist concepts and prototypes of AR-integrated devices that can revolutionise the very way in which we live. There are AR-equipped bionic lenses being worked upon and numerous smartphone apps already existing in the market.

The competition

By early 2000s, there were more than just a bunch of real-world applications for the technology. From videogames such as Quake (called ARQuake) to AR-enabled clothing, the uses were limitless. It was around this time that the idea of AR glasses was first explored. Infact, while Google is showcasing a "future" technology, com-

panies in the market already sell similar glasses with integrated displays for military, industrial and even commercial use.

Among the early adopters was the company Vuzix, whose first low-cost AR glasses, iWear VR920, were released in 2009. Targeted specifically at gamers and virtual world enthusiasts, they consist of two LCD displays fed real-time footage by an add-on camera.

Then there's Recon Instruments' MOD Live which at \$400 (around ₹20,000) promises to be a pretty powerful, GPS-based micro-fiber optics display that, once snapped onto a pair of compatible goggles, can connect via Bluetooth to an armband-mounted controller for the head-up display (HUD). Targeted specifically at skiers and snowboarders, the MOD Live can report real-time speed and jumping statistics and even map your trail route right in front of your eyes.

And while manufacturing and medical sectors are often cited as prime candidates for AR applications, there are presently a select few companies selling HUDs for much more varied purposes. For instance, take Brother, primarily a printing company, who in August 2011 announced the commercialisation of AiRScouter, a see-through type, head mounted display. The goggles use a single display design with a translucent LCD on top of the wearer's left eye. It can support information superimposed over the wearer's actual view. While stating that it's a "versatile technology



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